



◀ AMERICAN AIRBORNE ASSETS

Troops from the US First Cavalry Division leap from a UH-1 Iroquois helicopter (a “slick” Huey), in Vietnam. Although the Americans exploited their aerial advantage with skill, they were unable to prevail.

KEY EVENTS

1945–PRESENT

■ **1 October 1949** The People’s Republic of China is founded, after more than two decades of warfare, under Mao Zedong’s leadership.

■ **7 May 1954** French forces besieged in Dien Bien Phu, in Vietnam, surrender to the communist Vietminh. The French had hoped that they could defeat the Vietminh in a conventional military operation, but found themselves totally overwhelmed.

■ **8 March 1965** US Marines land near Da Nang, as part of an American effort to combat communist insurgency.

■ **13 October 1977** A Lufthansa airliner is hijacked by guerrillas in support of the German Red Army Faction. German special forces subsequently storm the aircraft in Mogadishu, Somalia, and release the 86 passengers unharmed.

■ **24 December 1979** The Soviet occupation of Afghanistan begins, prompting the US to supply Afghan Mujahideen resistance fighters covertly with money and arms.

■ **29 December 1992** A hotel in Aden, used by US troops on their way to Somalia, is bombed. It is al-Qaeda’s first attack.

■ **11 September 2001** Al-Qaeda (see p.408) launches terror attacks on America.

▼ HECKLER & KOCH MP5

Used by anti-terrorist forces, this submachine-gun is accurate, reliable, and has a relatively low recoil, enabling controlled automatic fire.

“Politics is war without bloodshed, while war is politics with bloodshed”

MAO ZEDONG, ON PROTRACTED WAR, MAY 1938

campaigns – the Contras, against the left-wing Nicaraguan government, and the Mujahideen, against the Soviet Union’s Red Army in Afghanistan. Towards the end of the 20th century, low-intensity, guerrilla-style warfare had also become endemic in parts of Africa – notably in the failed states of the Congo basin and the Horn of Africa – as warring bands fought for local supremacy. Guerrilla wars were predominantly rural in origin and character, while terrorism was mainly an urban phenomenon. Typical terrorist tactics such as assassination, extortion, kidnapping, and bombings were used by guerrilla groups – but from the 1960s onwards, terrorism began to develop a character of its own.

If guerrilla insurgencies were violent attempts to gain control of a state, terrorism was an extreme form of protest, often an attempt to publicize a cause, or destabilize a society. Terrorism took many forms, reflecting the differing backgrounds and grievances of its participants. It included middle-class angst against the capitalist state, given violent form by the German Red Army Faction, the spate of plane hijackings

in support of the Palestinian cause in the 1970s, and assassinations in Spain by the Basque separatist movement, ETA. However, for the West, the most worrying trend was the emergence of radical Islamist terrorists in the 1990s. Characterized by resentment towards the US and its allies, their attacks on the World Trade Center and the Pentagon in the US, in 2001, ushered in a new era in which the threat of large-scale terrorist attacks on civilian populations is never far from the public consciousness.

